

Social VR

How Academics Can Use Social VR for Research and Education

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ABSTRACT

While many VR demos involve two users or one using a virtual agent, few contemplate using social VR. Many live demos at industry conferences do not adequately address the social aspect of VR and will not explore its possibilities. Given that Immersive experiences are moving more and more to social VR experiences, it is crucial to discuss its development and implications in various applications, such as arts, games, entertainment, health, and education.

KEYWORDS

Virtual Reality, Education, Social Science

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1 ABSTRACT

Although desktop virtual reality platforms have been around for some time (like Second Life, for example), HMD-based platforms are recent and have yet to be explored. One of the recent applications of HMD-based environments has been Social VR, where several users can gather in an immersive VR environment through their headsets. From the interaction perspective, Social VR enriches the communication between people, through a rich media environment, with infinite possibilities of environments and personas. The rich HCI and peer-to-peer interaction in VR open up new avenues for exciting research and developments on HCI. Because very few people have already experimented with social VR, this installation focuses on bringing rich Social VR experiences to SIGGRAPH attendees, sparking discussions around future research and applications. One of the most significant Social VR implementation in education recently was conducted by researchers from the Virtual Human Interaction Lab (VHIL) at Stanford, who conducted two entire courses in social VR. The VHIL team will run the installation, teaching participants how to navigate in the Social VR platform and guide participants through highly interactive and high-standard Social VR experiences.

2 METHODS

The Social VR platform used for this demo will be ENGAGE VR (<https://engagevr.io/>). ENGAGE is company that VHIL has used for VR. The team running the installation has pioneered research in Social VR for education and human interaction in these environments. For the Virtual People class taught at Stanford, students were each given a Meta Quest 2 headset and would complete various tasks in virtual reality [Han et al., 2022]. For the SIGGRAPH demo in the Immersive Pavilion, researchers from this large-scale experiment will show participants how this software was used in the classroom and give a brief overview of some of the experiences students got to experience.

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